Report on Bhutan's Participation at the 28th Universal Postal Union Congress, Dubai

(7–20 September 2025)

"Leading the Change & Creating the Future"

The Universal Postal Union (UPU) extended an invitation to Bhutan to participate in the 28th UPU Congress, held in Dubai from 7–20 September 2025 vide letter reference number 2100(DPRM.PPRE.CCA)1115 dated 16 October 2024. As Bhutan a member of the UPU, it was a great privilege to take part in this historic Congress, convened every four years, where 192 postal leaders from around the globe gather to deliberate and decide on the future of the postal sector in a rapidly evolving world and The theme for the 2026–2029 Congress cycle is *"Leading the Change and Creating the Future"*.

Bhutanese delegation at the 28th Universal Postal Union Congress, Dubai.

Bhutan's delegation was led by Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay, Head of Delegation, Ministry of Infrastructure and Transport (MoIT), and Chairman of Bhutan Post, and comprised the following delegates:

1. Mr. Tashi Penjor, Director, Department of Human Settlement, MoIT

2. Ms. Bhavana Chhetri, Chief Urban Planner, Department of Human Settlement, MoIT
3. Mr. Karma Nidup, Chief Executive Officer, Bhutan Post
4. Mr. Jamyang Phuntsho, Head of Postal Services Department, Bhutan Post
5. Mr. Thinley Wangchuk, Head of Corporate Affairs and International Relations Department, Bhutan Post
6. Mrs. Rinchen Zangmo, Head of Corporate Services Department, Bhutan Post
7. Mrs. Wangmo Phuntsho Droenma, Head of Postal Operations Division, Bhutan Post.

Bhutan's participation in this high-level global forum underscores our country's continued commitment to international postal cooperation and its recognition of the vital role of postal services in socio-economic development in today's fast-changing global landscape.

Report on Proceedings – 7 September 2025

During the morning session, all UPU member delegations completed the registration process, obtained their official identification badges, and submitted their credentials to the Credentials Committee (C1).

EMS Cooperative General Assembly 2025.

The first day of the Congress in Dubai successfully convened the 28th General Assembly of the EMS Cooperative. The session, attended by key leadership including the UPU Director General and Deputy Director General, marked a pivotal moment to redefine the strategic direction of the Express Mail Service (EMS). The agenda focused on endorsing a forward-looking framework for 2026-2029, addressing evolving market challenges, and celebrating excellence within the Cooperative.

EMS Cooperative General Assembly Governing Board member

Opening Session

The Assembly was called to order with opening remarks from the UPU Director General (DG). The DG underscored the critical importance of the EMS service within the global postal network and introduced the new Strategy Business Plan for EMS. Key approvals secured during the opening session included:

1. The new EMS Awards standards (2026-2029)
2. An update on the implications of the US President's Executive Order on de-minimis values, highlighting the need for strategic adaptability among member posts.

EMS Cooperative General Assembly Gathers 176 Global UPU Members

The Chairman of the EMS Cooperative, Algeria Post, then presided over the meeting, outlining the core themes for the Cooperative's future, including market penetration, digital transformation, operational efficiency, innovation, and sustainability.

Agenda Items and Key Outcomes

The Assembly addressed a comprehensive agenda designed to set the strategic course for the next four years:

1. EMS Awards Ceremony: The Customer Care Awards were presented, recognizing excellence in service delivery among member posts.
2. Report of the 2025.1 General Assembly: The previous meeting's report was formally acknowledged.
3. Strategic Planning and Endorsement: The core of the session focused on seeking approval from UPU Members for three foundational documents:
    a. EMS Cooperative Strategic Plan (2026-2029): Outlining the roadmap for growth, innovation, and collaboration.
    b. EMS Awards Criteria (2026-2029): Establishing updated standards for recognizing performance excellence.
    c. Dubai Business Plan (2026-2029): Defining actionable objectives and initiatives to achieve the strategic goals.
4. Budget Approval: The proposed operational budget for the year 2026 was presented for review and approval.
5. Market Intelligence Presentation: A detailed analysis of the EMS market was shared, emphasizing:
    a. The massive growth of e-commerce, with the Asia-Pacific region projected to account for 40% of global transactions by 2027.
    b. The increasing threat and strategies of private competitors.
    c. The critical need to analyze market trends, competitor activities, and enhance EMS performance metrics to remain competitive.

Coordination Meeting with APPU member Countries:

The coordination meeting of APPU members, convened by the APPU Bureau, was attended by representatives from 21 member countries.

APPU Executives Coordinate Asia-Pacific Postal Union Session

The meeting was chaired by the APPU Executive Council Chairman, Mr. Wisitsova, alongside the Secretary General of APPU, Dr. Vinaya Prakash Singh.

Asia-Pacific Postal Union Sets Common Agenda on Eve of Dubai Congress

The discussions centered on key thematic areas, including digital transformation, postal financial services and remittances, development cooperation, and enhancing the resilience of the international postal network.

Further deliberations focused on consolidating positions on key papers and agenda items to be presented collectively in support of regionalization, improvement of postal service quality, effective utilization of the Quality of Service Fund, and strengthening postal financial services. The meeting also reviewed the importance of supporting APPU members in the Council of Administration (CA) and the Postal Operations Council (POC).

The meeting also discussed the issue of participation of Afghanistan and Myanmar in the forthcoming Dubai Postal Congress. Although both countries have secured the required credentials, the UPU has directed that they will not be admitted to participate in the Congress due to UN sanction against them. APPU recommended for support in admission to Congress. Additionally, the meeting considered the proposed change in nomenclature from "Restricted Union" to "Regional Union." It was agreed that, should this matter arise during the Congress sessions, all APPU member countries will collectively extend their support.

Report on Proceedings – 8 September 2025

The 28th Universal Postal Union (UPU) Congress commenced at 9:00 AM with the full attendance of delegates.

Agenda Items 5 & 6

The Director General of UPU, Mr. Masahiko Metoki, delivered the opening remarks, underlining the importance of addressing the global postal transformation. He highlighted the complexity of the challenges but emphasized the need to resolve them amicably, ensuring benefits for the majority of member countries.The Assistant Director General then proceeded with formal introductions. The Congress confirmed the establishment of Committees C1–C7 as proposed, and the Vice Chairman of Congress was appointed under Agenda Item 9.

Council of Administration Report

A comprehensive report was presented on the activities of the Council of Administration (CA), underscoring:

1. The continuity of postal operations between Congress cycles.
2. The need for modern, resilient, competitive, and efficient postal systems, with Senegal leading the discussion.

3. Approval of invited observers and ad hoc participants.

The CA Proposal for Remote Voting was also tabled, introducing temporary provisions limited to the Dubai Cycle (8–20 September 2025). Under this proposal, two-thirds of voting would be permitted remotely. The United States further submitted procedural amendments under Rules of Procedure 114(115)/192.

Agenda Item 13 – General Statements

1. Canada emphasized the urgent need for the postal sector to adapt to change, noting declining business volumes. Canada stressed that repeating the same approaches was unsustainable, calling for strategies aligned with evolving customer needs.
2. Slovenia underlined the importance of a digital and customer-focused postal ecosystem.
3. Saudi Arabia announced its general statement scheduled for 9 September 2025.
4. Côte d'Ivoire highlighted the critical role of social inclusion through postal networks.

Special Address – Chairman of 7X (UAE)

The Chairman of 7X Group (UAE) delivered a keynote address celebrating 150 years of postal history. His remarks focused on:

1. Transforming the international postal network into a living global network.
2. Ensuring parcels reach every doorstep worldwide.
3. Forging bold partnerships and advanced logistics networks.
4. Driving innovation, positioning 7X as a national champion.
5. Introducing digital home addressing alongside digital infrastructure, marking the 21st century vision of the postal sector.

UPU Global Leaders Summit

The Global Leaders Summit brought together heads of postal organizations and global partners.

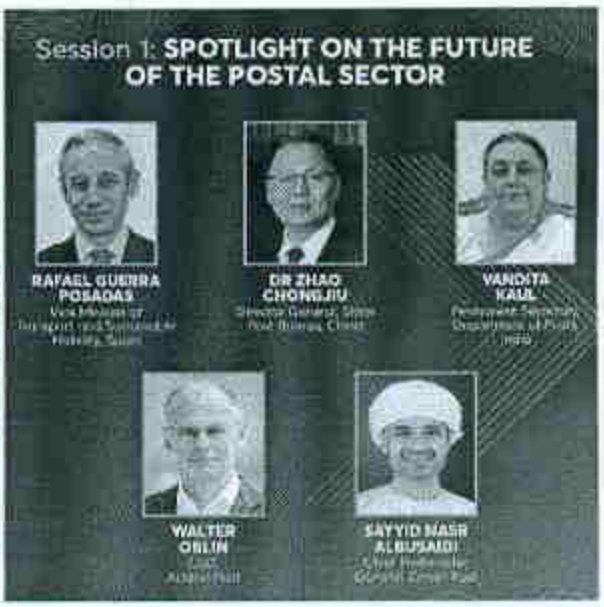
1. UPU Director General, Mr. Masahiko Metoki, set the tone by highlighting the role of postal networks in reshaping economies, modernizing postal service providers, and strengthening the postal ecosystem and service models.
2. The CEO of 7X Group shared insights on partnerships with Amazon and Tx Group, reinforcing the importance of e-commerce logistics and innovation-driven growth.

A high-level Leaders' Panel: "Shaping Tomorrow's Priorities" featured interventions from Portugal and Mongolia, focusing on:

1. Warehouse fulfilment and supply chain transformation.

2. The booming e-commerce sector.
3. The postal sector's need for strategic transformation and adaptability to change

UPU Global Leaders Submit:



UPU Global Leaders Submit

A high-level session was convened under the leadership of UPU Director General, Mr. Masahiko Metoki. The meeting brought together global postal leaders to deliberate on the pressing challenges and opportunities shaping the future of the postal sector.

Key Highlights:

1. Emphasis on global postal reforms and the importance of consensus-driven decision-making.
2. DG Metoki underlined the need for innovation, digital transformation, and cross-border cooperation to strengthen postal networks.
3. Leaders reaffirmed commitment towards sustainable development goals (SDGs) and enhancing postal contribution to economic and social growth.
4. Discussions centered around strengthening inclusivity, improving resilience, and ensuring universal service obligations amidst rapid technological and market changes

Report on Proceedings – 9 September 2025

Plenary Session

The Congress commenced with deliberations on voting procedures, including presentations on hybrid voting, followed by the adoption of Agenda Item 3.

General Statements

1. Japan highlighted Disaster Risk Management (DRM), Quality of Service (QoS) in sustainable ways, and proposed enhanced UPU support through the Japan Fund to address both individual and regional needs. Japan also reaffirmed its commitment to supporting the incumbent Director General in his re-election bid, contributing to the renovation of the UPU Headquarters in Berne, and strengthening global postal development.
2. The United States emphasized the magnitude of operational changes within the postal sector, calling for alignment of customs policies with national frameworks. The U.S. stressed the importance of a fair global postal system by continuing remuneration reforms through self-declared rates, ensuring fair competition in e-commerce. The U.S. also underscored the significance of security, particularly the ICS2 systems with de minimis thresholds from 29 August 2025, and urged timely action on related measures.

3. The United Arab Emirates underscored the principles of reliability, universality, inclusivity, and governance as the foundation of a strong global postal framework, advocating for sustainability within the international postal community.
4. Malaysia noted the decline in traditional mail volumes while highlighting the rapid growth of digital platforms and e-commerce. It further discussed restructuring the licensing framework, modernizing the Universal Service Obligation (USO), strengthening consumer protection, and ensuring postal security and resilience.
5. Australia reiterated the challenges faced by island nations and stressed the importance of diversification, while recognizing the country's role within the world's largest logistics network.
6. Israel highlighted the urgent need for speed, transparency, innovation, and modernization in postal services while acknowledging financial pressures and the responsibility of ensuring environmental sustainability.
7. Thailand emphasized the surge in e-commerce, advocating for a green transformation and sustainable postal practices.
8. Denmark focused on financial inclusion, addressing regional and global challenges, and strengthening postal governance.
9. Nepal and Uganda also presented national perspectives on strengthening postal development in line with global priorities.

Reports

1. Report of the Postal Operations Council (presented by the Chairman, France)
2. Report on the Council of Administration
3. Report of the Consultative Committee

Special Recognition for Bhutan Post

Bhutan Post was honoured with the prestigious Silver-Level Certification in Quality Management during the third plenary session. Among the 192 UPU member countries, only Cambodia, Ghana, and Bhutan received this distinguished recognition.

Director General and Deputy Director General with the CEO, Head PSD and Head CAIRD

This certification, which is equivalent to the ISO 9001 standard, reaffirms Bhutan Post's commitment to operational excellence, service reliability, and adherence to international best practices in postal quality management.

The award was received on behalf of Bhutan Post by:

1. Mr. Karma Nidup, Chief Executive Officer
2. Mr. Jamyang Phuntsho, Head of Postal Services Department
3. Mr. Thinley Wangchuk, Head of Corporate Affairs and International Relations Department

Bhutan's delegation alongside the other recipients of UPU Designated Operators.

The recognition was conferred by UPU Director General Mr. Masahiko Metoki and Deputy Director General Mr. Marjan Osvald. This milestone underscores Bhutan Post's dedication to raising service standards, enhancing international confidence, and contributing to the transformation of the global postal network.

General Policy and Work of the Union:

1. Adoption of procedures for the elections of the Director General and Deputy Director General.
2. Management and financial support for the Council of Administration (CA) and Postal Operations Council (POC).

Bhutan Post – Sideline Meeting Agenda

UPU Congress, Dubai 2025

Attendees:

1. Dasho Phuntsho, Chairman, MoIT
2. Mr.Tashi Penjor,Director, Department of Human Settlements, MoIT
3. Ms.Bhawana Chhetri, Chief Urban Planner, DHS, MoIT

4. Mr.Thinley Wangchuk, Deputy General Manager, Corporate Affairs & International Relations Department, Bhutan Post

Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay (Head of Delegation), Mr. Tashi Penjor (Director, DHS, MoIT), Head CAIRD, Bhutan Post, the Secretary of India Post, and Mr. Ram Shikaria (Director General, India Post).

India Post

1. Visit of the Secretary of India Post to Bhutan (tentative, with confirmation to be communicated through the Ministry of Foreign Affairs – India).

MoU discussions to cover:

a. Cooperation in training, knowledge-sharing, and capacity building.
b. Enhancing supply chain connectivity and cross-border e-commerce.
c. Collaboration on digital address systems and technological advancements, including UPI front-end integration.
d. Philatelic exchanges and cultural cooperation.
e. Exploring cooperation in financial services.
f. Establishment of a Joint Working Group.

Upon agreement, the above agenda points (a–f) will be formalized and their implementation initiated immediately, without awaiting the formal signing of the MoU. The action plan will commence following the Secretary of India Post's visit to Bhutan, with respective focal persons already designated for each agenda item.

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Second Session of Plenary 3

Committee 3: General Policy and Management of the Work of the Union

Agenda Item 6(d): UPU Role in the Wider Postal Sector and Among New Players

The discussions under this agenda item focused on aligning the role of the UPU with the broader international trade framework, including potential cooperation with the World Trade Organization (WTO). Key interventions included:

1. Oman (Proposal):
    a. Reinforce global postal standardization.
    b. Enhance collaboration between traditional postal services and emerging e-commerce markets.
    c. Promote interoperability and sustainability.
2. United States: Did not support the proposal.
3. United Kingdom: Stressed the importance of the Consultative Committee and advocated for international standards within the Dubai cycle.
4. Germany & Netherlands: Opposed the proposal, raising concerns about exchange of mail and implications for the UPU Acts.
5. Brazil: Expressed concerns.
6. Belgium: Suggested UPU legal advisors could support through IT tools and access mechanisms.
7. Mexico: Expressed support.
8. Spain: Requested further clarification.
9. France: Supported selective aspects of the proposal.
10. Uruguay: Opposed, citing duplication of standards.
11. Italy: Reserved position.

12. Canada: Recalled prior debates in the CA and POC; noted the proposal had not been approved and emphasized governmental implications.
13. China: Supported UPU's role as standard-setter but sought clarity on specific functions.
14. Oman (Rebuttal): Reiterated bold reforms were necessary for global standardization.

Legal Advisor's Intervention: Clarified that decisions were already taken by the CA to provide certain UPU tools and acts for broader access, subject to further approval.

Outcome:

1. Congress decision deferred pending further deliberation by the POC, CA, and RIMG Board.

Agenda Item 8: Customs Policy and Regulatory Issues

Discussions centered around Electronic Advance Data (EAD) and regulatory frameworks, including:

1. Stop Act, ICS2 R2 & R3 requirements.
2. Recommendations of the POC for EAD implementation.

Lunch Session:

Special meeting on Delivery Duty Paid (DDP) mechanism:

1. Emphasis on collection of tax at origin.
2. API integration through electronic advance data and customs declaration systems.

Committee 4 (Convention):

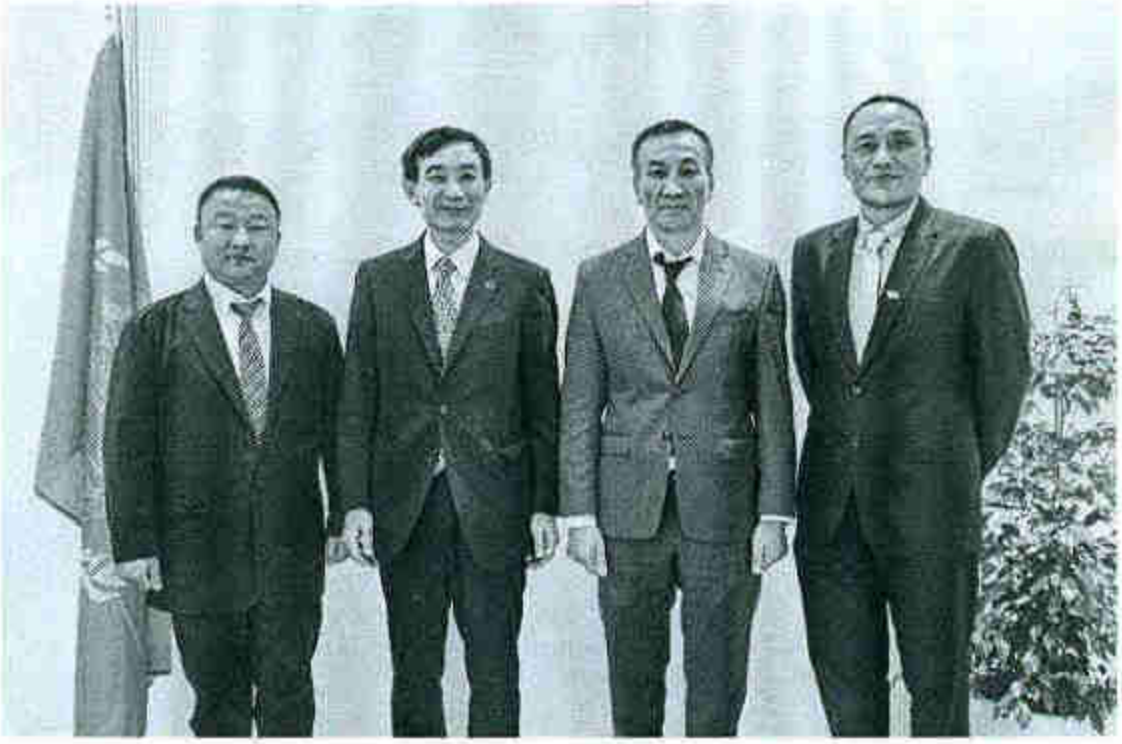
Deliberations on the Integrated Product Plan (2026–2029) and Integrated Remuneration Plan (2026–2030):

1. Basic and supplementary services.
2. Indemnities and liabilities of designated operators.
3. Parcel post land and sea rates.
4. Transit charges and terminal dues (general provisions, self-declared rates, target vs. transitional systems).
5. Authority of the POC to fix charges and rates.

Sideline Meeting with the Director General of the UPU

Attendees:

1. Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay, Chairman,MoIT
2. Mr. Karma Nidup, Chief Executive Officer,Bhutan Post
3. Mr. Thinley Wangchuk, Head, Corporate Affairs & International Relations,Bhutan Post



Meeting with UPU Director General led by Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay (Chairman), Mr. Karma Nidup (CEO), and Mr. Thinley Wangchuk (Head, CAIRD).

Discussion Points:

1. Bhutan Post's 10X Growth Plan – Strategic roadmap for accelerated growth.
2. Support for G
3. Gelephu Mindfulness City (GMC) – Leveraging logistics to support GMC's vision.
4. Digital Transformation & Modernization – Advancing customer-centric digital solutions.
5. Drone Logistics & Innovation – Exploration of UPU-approved "LIFT" (Last-mile Innovation through Flight Technology) pilot project.
6. Green & Sustainable Service Delivery.

Special Session: Customs Policy Dialogue:

Attended by representatives of UPU member countries.

Key Highlights:

1. Opening Remarks: DG referenced the US President's Executive Order (25 July 2025) relating to customs and duty regulations.
2. Policy Directions:
    a. Recognition that each country retains sovereign customs policies.
    b. DDP solution proposed by UPU for duty collection across the postal network.
    c. Frameworks discussed at national, regional, and global levels.

Discussion Points:

1. DDP Solution Models: Flat rate, Ad Valorem.
2. Concerns raised by restricted unions regarding:
    a. Short notification periods.
    b. Operational disruptions.
    c. Airline refusals.
    d. Duty collection at origin.
    e. Frequent changes in customs regulations.
3. Consideration of legal provisions for tax collection at source.

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C5 – Postal Financial Service

1. Attended by CEO, PSD & POD (Secondary Hall).

C6 – Development & Cooperation

1. Attended by Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay, Chief DHS, and CSD (Main Hall).
2. Discussions covered:
    a. DRM and Contingency Plans
    b. Comprehensive report on the work of Committee 4 (Development Cooperation & Technical Assistance)
    c. UPU Development Cooperation Policy (2026–2029)
    d. Japan's proposal: Regionalized initiatives tailored to disaster risk management and digitalization.

e. Quality of Service Fund (QSF):
   i. General proposals (POC) and amendments.
   ii. Convention proposal on QSF.
f. Achievements in Development Cooperation & Technical Assistance:
   i. Operational performance progress.
   ii. Postal sector modernization.
   iii. Capacity building solutions.
   iv. Innovation in postal approaches.
   v. Outreach to the diplomatic community.
   vi. Expansion of UPU's regional presence.
g. UPU Project Implementation: Updates on financial resource execution.
h. Designated Operators: Delivery performance, remuneration, EAD compliance, IT tools, CDS, postal security, ORE, last-mile delivery, digital adoption, and e-commerce integration.

Sideline Meetings

1. Uganda (10:00 Dubai time)
   a. Mr. Otunnu Okot Fred, Director Corporate Affairs.
   b. Purpose: Support meeting for Uganda's CA candidacy.
   c. Attendees: Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay, Thinley Wangchuk (Head, CAIRD).
2. China (POC/CA support)
   a. Attendees: Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay, Thinley Wangchuk (Head, CAIRD).
3. Mongolia (POC support)
   a. Attendees: Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay, Thinley Wangchuk (Head, CAIRD).

Special Session – Women Empowerment (SDG 5)

1. Statements delivered emphasizing:
   a. UPU's mandate as a single postal territory.
   b. Role of technical support, collaboration, and development.
   c. Development cooperation projects with a gender-inclusive approach.

Terminal Dues & Remuneration

1. PEG Format Separation: General provisions clarified.
2. Transit Charges & Remuneration Rates:

a. Germany: Amendment proposal on remuneration.

b. Egypt:

   i. Proposed removal of supplementary remuneration (noted potential implications).

   ii. Emphasized penalties for failure to provide EAD, as EAD is mandatory and forwarded to the recipient.

c. Cuba: Raised concerns on compromised and imbalanced rates.

   i. Suggested structure:

      1. Per item basis.
      2. Per kg basis.
      3. Basic rate for volumes below 50 tonnes.

Postal Financial Service – Congress Decision:

At the 28th Universal Postal Congress held in Dubai, key decisions were taken on the future of Postal Financial Services (PFS), emphasizing inclusivity, affordability, and sustainability.

1. Fee Structure Reform

   a. Member countries endorsed a transparent and harmonized fee structure for cross-border postal financial services.

   b. The new model seeks to balance cost recovery with the need to maintain affordable access for citizens, especially in developing and least-developed countries.

   c. Provisions were also made to review charges periodically in line with technological modernization and digital transaction costs.

2. India's Role in Financial Inclusion & USO

   a. India announced its commitment to further strengthening the use of the postal network for financial services under the Universal Service Obligation (USO) framework.

   b. India Post will serve as a regional driver to expand affordable financial access, particularly in underserved and rural areas, by leveraging postal savings networks, digital payment platforms, and UPU–IP collaboration.

c. This initiative aligns with the Congress vision of integrating financial inclusion with postal development, ensuring that postal networks remain a trusted and universal channel for basic financial services.

3. Global Outlook
    a. Congress reaffirmed that Postal Financial Services are a pillar of the UPU's Development and Cooperation agenda for 2026–2029.
    b. Member countries committed to cooperate on interoperability, digital security
    c. standards, and cross-border remittance facilitation through the postal channel.

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Committee 6: Development & Cooperation

Quality of Service Fund (QSF):

1. Congress reviewed matters related to the QSF (Doc. 33).
2. Proposal 06 – Quality of Service Fund:
    a. Bhutan delivered an intervention expressing strong support for the QSF mechanism.
    b. Bhutan highlighted that, as a small landlocked country, it has greatly benefited from QSF, particularly through LDC Special Account projects.
    c. QSF funding enabled Bhutan's transition to electric delivery vehicles under green initiatives, significantly improving quality of service delivery.
    d. Bhutan endorsed the proposal and urged that the fund reflect the needs of smaller member countries.
3. Proposal 20 – Amendment to Proposal 06:
    a. Proposed removal by GMS.
    b. Approved through vote.
4. Convention Proposal – QSF E-Format (Group C, except M-Bag):
    a. Discussions continued with interventions from Nepal (solidarity and ongoing protest).
    b. APPU Secretary General voiced concerns.

Committee 4: Convention

Integrated Quality of Service Plan (IQP):

1. Discussion covered the following:
    a. IQP 2026–2029.
    b. Integrated Quality of Service Plan.
    c. Quality of service standards and targets

Proposals:

1. Freedom of Transmit – USA: Approved.
2. Radioactive Substances – Iran: Proposal that M-Bags shall not transmit radioactive substances. Legal experts confirmed prohibition.
    a. Voting outcome: 83 in favor, 9 against, 25 abstentions → Approved.

Plenary 3/6: Elections:

1. Rules of Procedure reviewed.
2. Pacific Island Group: Discussions on SID applicable rules.
3. Council Membership:
    a. CA – 41 members.
    b. POC – 48 members.
4. Two options were considered:
    a. Proposal of a General Nature 21 – Adopted.
    b. Proposal of a General Nature 22 – Under consideration.

Any Other Business (AOB):

1. Additional matters were noted under AOB for further follow-up

Report on Proceedings – 14 September 2025

Committee 3: General Policy and Management of the Work of the Union

Agenda Item 6.0 – Role of the Union for Standardization (Oman Proposal)

Oman introduced agenda item 6.0 concerning the Union's role in standardization, proposing inclusive parameters for uniformity among all Designated Operators. This was linked with Proposal of a General Nature No. 09 on the further development of the customs policy and regulatory framework.

1. Report on Customs Policy and Regulatory Issues (8a) was presented, followed by discussion on Further Development of the Customs Policy and Regulatory Framework (8b).
2. Germany emphasized a future outlook, suggesting the UPU should evolve towards a single postal territory, reinforcing freedom of transit.
3. The United States proposed an amendment to address emerging customs and security requirements, noting duplication of content across existing documents.
4. Nigeria, India, and Uganda opposed the amendment.
5. Greece opposed, while expressing general support for an amendment in principle.
6. Timor-Leste and Canada interventions noted.
7. Japan abstained.
8. Kenya opposed.
9. Belgium supported the US amendment.
10. France, Spain, Tunisia, Ghana, Burkina Faso, and Egypt expressed support in varying forms, with Egypt calling for a comprehensive review report.
11. Indonesia intervention noted.

Decision

The US amendment was rejected, and the assembly resolved to retain Proposal No. 09 in its original form.

Agenda Item 6d – Oman Proposal on Enhancement of the Role of UPU as Postal Standardization Authority

Oman urged the Union to continue work on enhancing its role in postal standardization, proposing group formation and addition of appropriate text to broaden perspectives and enable future review. Interventions were made by Kenya, US, Brazil, France, UK, and Canada.

Sideline Meeting

Topic: Sustainable Development and Climate-Related Matters

Expert: Mr. James Hale, Sustainable Development Expert

Bhutan Delegation:

1. Mr. Karma Nidup, CEO
2. Mr. Jamyang Phuntsho, Head of PSD
3. Mrs. Rinchen Zangmo, Head of CSD

Discussion Points: Addressed strategies for climate resilience and sustainability within postal operations.

Committee 3 – Agenda Item 9

Proposal of a General Nature No. 11 – Postal Regulatory Framework

Malawi introduced the proposal on a harmonized methodology for defining the postal sector. Belgium suggested an amendment, which was incorporated into the proposal.

Sustainable Development

A Quorum of 109 members was achieved.

Agenda Item 7a – Climate Action (20m CHF Initiative)

Discussions centered on market access, cost efficiency, energy security, resilient infrastructure, social innovation, and funding pledges by several member countries.

Key elements included:

1. Draft MoU – contents presented and taken note of.
2. Green Initiatives and Last-Mile Delivery (LMD).
3. Circular Economy approaches.
4. Cross-sectoral engagement opportunities.
5. Access to finance for climate action.
6. Establishment of a Climate Knowledge and Innovation Hub.
7. Secretariat services to be coordinated by the International Bureau.

7b:Gender Quality:

SDG-5 : Gender equality

a. Women's empowerment
b. Opportunities
c. Egypt: 30% of Congress Representation
d. India-Support

UPU Strategy(2026-2029)-Item 3B- Dubai Cycle:

Goals:

Goal 1: Leveraging the single postal territory:

Goal 2: Strengthening the global postal ecosystem through innovation for facilitating communication and trade

Goal 3: Enabling postal development through enhanced cooperation and regionalization:

Workplan:

1. Draft Dubai Business Plan
2. Dubai Domain Work (DDW)

UPU member countries attending the 28th Universal Postal Congress voted to allow the State of **Palestine** additional rights to participate in UPU decision-making processes as an observer.

Passed with the support of 107 UPU member countries – with three countries voting against the proposal's adoption and 29 abstentions – the resolution instructs the UPU's decision-making bodies to allow the State of Palestine the following additional modalities for participation:

1. The right to be seated in alphabetical order among UPU member countries;
2. The right to raise points of order and procedural motions, excepting the right to challenge decisions of the chair;
3. The right to be included on the list of speakers for agenda items other than Palestinian and Middle East issues;
4. The right to make statements on behalf of a group of member countries;
5. The right to explain, orally or in writing, proposals submitted by member countries;
6. The right to co-sponsor proposals and amendments from member countries as a supporting observer;
7. The right to make explanations of votes on behalf of a group of member countries;
8. The right of reply regarding the positions of a group of member countries;
9. The right to propose and request the inclusion of items on the provisional agenda of UPU bodies; and
10. The right for the flag of the State of Palestine to be raised at UPU headquarters and (as the case may be) other offices of the organization after the flags of member countries.

The resolution was accompanied by associated proposals to amend the rules of procedure of the UPU's Congresses. Those amendments were adopted with the approval of 102 member countries, with four votes against the amendments and 27 abstentions.

The State of Palestine was originally granted observer status within the UPU during the organization's 1999 Universal Postal Congress (Congress Resolution C 115/Beijing 1999). This decision gave the State of Palestine rights to directly exchange postal services with other UPU member countries and the right to participate in all UPU conferences and bodies, including general debate, with the limitation that points of order raised by Palestine and its co-sponsorship

of draft resolutions should concern only Palestine and the Middle East. The delegation was also to be seated immediately following the last UPU member country.

As an observer, the State of Palestine does not have the right to vote in UPU bodies.

Committee 2: Finance

Highlights:

1. Quorum: 78.
2. Agenda adoption: Congress Document 4.Rev 2.
3. Key Items:
    a. Contribution System and Arrears: Council Administration approved the yearly contributions.
    b. Building Renovation: Reviewed and noted.
    c. Financial Statements & Audit Reports (2020–2023): Published on the UPU website.
    d. Union's Financial Position: Remains stable with improvements in receivable collections, especially from USPS.
    e. Quality of Service Fund (QSF): Expected to decline owing to a significant drop in letter mail volumes.
    f. Liabilities: Noted long-term staff liabilities aligned to UN scale and retirement schemes.
    g. Translation Services: Maintained in Arabic, English, Chinese and Russian.

Union Programme and Budget 2022–2025

1. Congress approved the summary of the financial report 2022–2025.
2. The consolidated accounts for 2020–2023 were adopted.
3. Draft resolution on Swiss assistance in Union finance was approved.
4. Funding of the Obligation of the Union Provident Scheme: A separate scheme, similar to the UN Pension Fund, was endorsed to support employee benefits.

Integrated Postal Development (IPD) and Unified Data Platform (UDP)

1. The Congress noted that data is a critical tool for timely and informed decision-making through AI-driven insights.
2. Key tenets of the Unified Data Platform (UDP) include:
    a. Compliance with international standards.
    b. Data Governance.
    c. Data Security.
3. Types of postal data currently handled by the UDP:
    a. Electronic Data Interchange (EDI) messages.
    b. Tracking and tracing information.
    c. Reach, Reliability, Resilience and Relevance (the "4Rs") data metrics to measure postal performance and improve customer experience.

Report on Proceedings – 16 September 2025

Plenary: Committee 3 – General Policy and Work of the Union

Attendance:

155 Member Countries present (78 required for quorum).

1. UPU Strategy and Draft Business Plan 2026–2029

The draft business plan was presented, outlining three strategic goals and related budget requirements:

1. Goal 1: Leveraging the single postal territory through an effective rules-based system
    a. Focus on improving cross-border postal supply chains, modernizing regulatory frameworks, streamlining customs, enhancing last-mile delivery and establishing regional postal hubs.
    b. Budget: CHF 17.54 million (regular) + CHF 27.39 million (voluntary and services) = CHF 44.94 million total.
2. Goal 2: Strengthening the global postal ecosystem through innovation
    a. Support innovation, e-commerce, logistics, social/financial inclusion, and service diversification.
    b. Budget: CHF 23.60 million (regular) + CHF 64.59 million (voluntary and services) = CHF 88.19 million total.

3. Goal 3: Enabling postal development through enhanced cooperation and regionalization
    a. Strengthen technical assistance, regionalization, partnerships, and ensure no member country is left behind.
    b. Integration of restricted unions in postal development emphasized.

Domain Work Proposals (DWPs)

1. Tier 1 (within Abidjan ceiling): 36 DWPs covering physical services, logistics, EMS, transport, security, customs, standardization, quality of service, innovation, digital transformation, trade inclusion, financial inclusion, cyber resilience, postal payments, partnerships, philately, UPU*Clearing, and last-mile delivery.
2. Tier 2A: Two DWPs (Emergency & Solidarity Fund; International Bureau cyber resilience) with a proposed additional CHF 2.49 million allocation over four years (approved at Riyadh Extraordinary Congress).
3. Tier 2B: Five new DWPs (201–205) addressing cyber resilience expansion, transforming post offices into digital hubs, extending addressing services, expanding the Emergency & Solidarity Fund, and broadening regionalization activities. Total ask: CHF 4.71 million (3.03% increase to the expenditure ceiling).
4. Tier 3: DWPs funded solely by voluntary contributions and sales of services. Target: CHF 82.3 million over four years.

Key Decisions and Voting Outcomes

1. Work Domain 24 (Mainstreaming SDGs): Amendment to delete item rejected – 42 in favour, 74 against, 12 abstentions (total 128).
2. Decision 18D06: Revised rules for effective decision-making (including POC and CA elections) – approved.
3. Draft Dubai Business Plan (Tiers 1, 2A, 2B and 3) – noted and approved for submission to Congress.

Restricted Unions

Proposal by Mexico to discuss elevating restricted unions to general unions under Article 9 of the UPU Constitution.

1. Restricted unions remain key to regional cooperation and strategy implementation (19 currently in operation, including APPU, PAPU, POSTEUROP, PUASP, etc.).
2. Congress agreed to continue cooperation and synergy with restricted unions and reaffirmed their role in implementing the world postal strategy and regional development plans.

Decision:

All member countries adopted and approved the proposed nomenclature through an amendment to Article 9 of the UPU Constitution, with a majority supporting the proposal and its subsequent adoption.

Report on Proceedings – 17 September 2025

Report on the UPU Contribution System – 28th Congress

The Council of Administration (CA), following Istanbul Congress Resolution C 29/2016, has been mandated to review the UPU contribution system to ensure the Union's long-term financial sustainability. A new task force established after the Abidjan Congress examined scenarios not foreseen under the current rules, notably decreases in the overall number of contribution units (CUs).

Under the current system (article 151 of the General Regulations):

1. Countries below their UN-assessed economic capacity ("type 1 and 2") are invited to increase Contribution Units by at least two per Congress cycle to benefit from the reduced Contribution Unit rate.
2. Countries above their capacity ("type 3") may reduce contribution units within limits while retaining the reduced contribution units rate.

Legal ambiguities regarding contribution unit calculations in cases of no change or decreases led the Council Administration to create a task force (2023.2 session) with broad member participation.

The task force presented three options to the CA:

1. Option A (preferred): Any contribution unit increases benefits type 2 and 3 countries; any contribution unit decreases costs are shared by all countries.
2. Option B (China): Countries decreasing contribution units pay the baseline (non-reduced) contribution unit rate.

3. Option C (Canada): A percentage-based adjustment (mandatory contribution unit increases for countries below capacity and controlled reductions for those above).

Following discussions (2024.2 session), the CA:

1. Agreed by consensus to continue work on Option A for submission to the 28th Congress.
2. Discontinued work on Option B.
3. Recommended further study of Option C by a new standing group on contributions in the next Congress cycle.

Accordingly, only Option A is submitted for amendment of article 151 at the 28th Congress.

Change in Contribution

As presented by the International Bureau of the UPU, Bhutan's contribution has been increased from 0.5 to 1 unit. This increase results from Bhutan's reclassification from a Least Developed Country (LDC) to a Developing Country at the Riyadh Congress.

Canada – Proposal of a General Nature

1. Countries paying more than their UN-assessed capacity can lower their contribution units a bit each Congress cycle (by the greater of 1 unit or 15%, but not below the UN level)
2. Countries paying less than their UN-assessed capacity are asked to gradually increase their contribution units (by at least 2 units or 15% each Congress cycle) until they reach the UN level.
3. If a country does not increase as invited, it cannot benefit from any lowering of the unit value created by others increasing.

Any shortfall from reductions will be shared collectively by all member countries under article 20.3.

Rationale

1. This proposal replaces the existing arbitrary two-unit threshold with a percentage-based approach to ensure fairness and proportionality. It enables countries paying above their UN scale to gradually reduce contributions and encourages those below to increase theirs, aligning contributions more closely with economic capacity. It also allows adjustments for countries where 15% represents less than a whole unit and supports maintaining or lowering the overall contribution unit value for the benefit of all members.
2. The item was determined not to be an amendment. A new proposal from Canada (15.151.2.Rev 2) was tabled. Following a quorum check, Egypt and Kenya requested a

secret ballot. The voting results were: 49 in favour, 69 against, and 17 abstentions. With 69 votes against, the Congress rejected the proposal.

Sideline Meeting with BiBi Money

Participants: CEO, PSD, CAIRD

The CEO, PSD and CAIRD, along with the CEO of Bibi Money

Key Decisions:

1. Further communication will be exchanged with BiBi Money to share technical aspects of the proposed collaboration.
2. A three-month trial phase will be initiated for onboarding BiBi Money without any upfront service charges.
3. The brand name and scope of services will be confirmed, with focus on financial remittance services for both domestic and international markets.
4. A Technical Committee will be constituted to review and oversee implementation.
5. A case study on operations across eight post offices will be prepared and presented to support decision-making.

APPU Members Pre-Election Meeting

APPU Bureau: Secretary General (SG), Mr. Sandeep,Consultant

Opening: The meeting was opened by the Secretary General.

Mr. Thinley Wangchuk, Head of CAIRD, and Ms. Bhawana Chhetri, Chief Urban Planner, MoIT

Programme of Proceedings:

10:00 a.m. – Election of the Director General (by acclamation)

10:10 a.m. – Election of the Deputy Director General

11:50 a.m. – Announcement of the results of the Deputy Director General election

Following – General statements by Member Countries

2:10 p.m. – Election of the Council of Administration (CA)

3:50 p.m. – Announcement of the results of the CA election

4:10 p.m. – Election of the Postal Operations Council (POC)

5:40 p.m. – Announcement of the results of the POC election

Balloting will be conducted using the Optical Mark Recognition (OMR) sheet system to ensure accuracy and transparency in vote counting.

C4 – Convention Session

Agenda 13.Rev 1:

The United States presented options for dispatching items containing goods to reduce the need to return empty receptacles. The proposal was adopted by the Committee.

Japan Post Proposals:

Proposals under 20.4 and 20.17.3 were submitted and adopted.

Supplementary Services (Agenda 20.18.5 and 20.18.8):

Iran and Japan Post proposed supplementary services. Canada, Turkey, Poland and Germany expressed that they could not accept the proposals due to insufficient destination facilities and the absence of an EAD option from the UPU. Consequently, Iran and Japan withdrew their proposals.

Germany Proposal – International Reply Coupons (IRC):

Germany proposed withdrawal of the IRC (20.18.6) effective January 2027 due to declining usage. The proposal was supported by New Zealand, Ireland, China, Egypt and Liechtenstein and was removed by majority vote.

Other Decisions:

1. Article 135 of the General Regulations deleted (forms).
2. Article 19 – Standardization of terminology (20.19.2) accepted.
3. Article 20.19.3 – Japan's proposal on letters adopted.
4. Article 21 – Not adopted; difficulty in adoption of Article 22 noted.
5. Article 20.21.1 – Supported by Belarus; subsequently rejected.
6. Article 22 & 20.22.2 – Liability of tracking service mandatory (Belarus).
7. Article 23 – Non-liability of Member Countries and Designated Operators adopted.
8. Articles 35 (Settlement of Accounts), Paragraph 3: Yes – 64; No – 45; Abstentions – 8; amended accordingly.

Meeting in the U.S. *De Minimis*

A meeting on the U.S. *de minimis* threshold was held at the International Bureau at 17:30, attended by Mr. Jamyang Phuntsho and Ms. Wangmo Phuntsho Droenma. The session was organized as a question-and-answer forum between Designated Operators and U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials.

Key Points Raised:

1. CBP clarified that the U.S. defines "bona fide gift" differently; undelivered items will be returned.

2. India Post inquired about acceptance of items without HS codes; CBP responded negatively.
3. India Post highlighted exchange rate fluctuations between booking and delivery; CBP stated such fluctuations are not accepted.
4. CBP emphasized the requirement to indicate the country of origin on all items.
5. CBP noted that fifteen qualified parties are present at the Congress, of which four were represented at this meeting.

Report on Proceedings – 18 September 2025

Session: Plenary 4/4

The Universal Postal Union (UPU) Congress convened on 18 September 2025 in Dubai for its fourth plenary session. A quorum of 141 was confirmed. The agenda for the day covered the elections of the Director General (DG), Deputy Director General (DDG), the Council of Administration (CA), and the Postal Operations Council (POC), along with related announcements and statements.

Credentials Committee

The Credentials Committee had met on 8 September 2025. Members present were El Salvador, India, New Zealand, the United Arab Emirates, the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, and the United States of America. Cameroon and Iraq were absent.

Credentials and proxies were found to be in due and proper form for 164 member countries. Credentials for Afghanistan and Myanmar were postponed pending guidance from the United Nations. Sixteen member countries are under sanctions. A total of 158 UPU member countries were physically present.

Elections Programme of Proceedings

1. 10:00 a.m. – Election of the Director General (by acclamation)
2. 10:10 a.m. – Election of the Deputy Director General
3. 11:50 a.m. – Announcement of the results of the DDG election
4. Following – General statements by member countries
5. 2:10 p.m. – Election of the Council of Administration (CA)
6. 3:50 p.m. – Announcement of the results of the CA election
7. 4:10 p.m. – Election of the Postal Operations Council (POC)

8. 5:40 p.m. – Announcement of the results of the POC election

Director General and Deputy Director General Elections

Japan's Masahiko Metoki was re-elected by acclamation as Director General of the UPU for a second term. Mr. Metoki has led the UPU since 2021, having previously served as Senior Vice President for International Affairs at Japan Post and Chair of the UPU's Postal Operations Council (2012–2021). His current mandate ends on 31 December 2025; his second term will run from 1 January 2026 to 31 December 2029.

Marjan Osvald of Slovenia was also re-elected as Deputy Director General, receiving 99 votes. Mr. Osvald brings over 24 years of experience in international postal operations, strategy, and sales, and previously served as Senior Adviser to the Executive Management of the Post of Slovenia. His second term will likewise begin on 1 January 2026 and run until 31 December 2029.

Results of the DDG election:

1. Marjan Osvald (Slovenia): 99 votes
2. Isaac Gnamba-Yao (Republic of Côte d'Ivoire): 57 votes
3. Invalid ballots: 1

All UPU members completed casting of paper votes by 10:35 a.m.

Signing of Universal Postal Union Acts:

Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay (Head of Delegation), Mr. Karma Nidup (CEO) and Mr. Jamyang Phuntsho (Head, PSD) at the signing of the UPU Acts.

The Head of Delegation, Dasho Phuntsho Tobgay, together with the accompanying member delegates, formally signed the UPU Acts on behalf of Bhutan, subject to subsequent ratification by the Royal Government

Council of Administration (CA)

Fifty-two candidacies were submitted for 41 CA seats. Several candidacies were subsequently withdrawn. The CA retained its power to delegate invitations for the 29th UPU Congress. Results of the CA election and allocation of seats were announced at 3:50 p.m.

Result of CA Elections 2026-2029:

1. Australia
2. Azerbaijan
3. Bangladesh
4. Barbados
5. Brazil
6. Cameroon
7. Canada
8. Chile
9. Costa Rica
10. Czechia
11. Egypt
12. El Salvador
13. Fiji
14. France
15. Ghana
16. India
17. Indonesia
18. Italy
19. Japan
20. Jordan
21. Madagascar
22. Mali
23. Morocco
24. Nigeria
25. Norway
26. Peru
27. Poland
28. Portugal
29. Rep. of Korea
30. Saudi Arabia
31. Seychelles
32. Slovakia
33. Slovenia
34. Thailand
35. Türkiye
36. Uganda
37. Ukraine
38. United Arab Emirates
39. United Rep. of Tanzania
40. United States of America
41. Zimbabwe

Postal Operations Council (POC)

Forty-eight members contested the POC election. Côte d'Ivoire withdrew its candidacy. A total of 159 ballots were received and counted. The results of the POC election were announced at 5:40 p.m.

List of member countries elected to the Postal Operations Council by the Dubai Congress

1. Algeria
2. Argentina
3. Australia
4. Austria
5. Azerbaijan
6. Barbados
7. Belgium
8. Botswana
9. Brazil
10. Bulgaria
11. Cabo
12. Verde
13. Canada
14. China
15. Cuba
16. Denmark
17. Egypt
18. Finland
19. France
20. Germany
21. Guatemala
22. Guinea
23. India
24. Indonesia
25. Italy
26. Japan
27. Kazakhstan
28. Kenya
29. Morocco
30. New Zealand
31. Oman
32. Paraguay
33. Poland
34. Samoa
35. Saudi Arabia
36. Senegal Serbia
37. Seychelles
38. Slovenia
39. Spain
40. Switzerland
41. Thailand
42. Tunisia Türkiy
43. Ukraine
44. United Arab Emirates
45. United Kingdom of Great Britain
46. Northern Ireland United
47. Rep. of Tanzania
48. United States of America

Statements by Member Countries

During the session, general statements were delivered by Zimbabwe, Uganda, Cameroon, Barbados, India, Ukraine, Tanzania (video statement), Cambodia, Indonesia, Costa Rica, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Denmark, Benin, Russia, Côte d'Ivoire, Burkina Faso, Korea, Guinea, Kenya, Algeria, Mongolia, Guatemala, Tunisia, Maldives, Colombia, Lesotho, Chad, South Africa, Timor-Leste, Bhutan, Syria, Bolivia, and Greece.

Other Agenda Items

1. Agenda Item 8: Ratification matters.
2. Agenda Item 9: General statements.
3. Agenda Item 10: Announcement of the DDG election results (IB).
4. Agenda Item 11: Quorum confirmed at 142.
5. Agenda Item 12: Election of the Council of Administration.
6. Agenda Item 19: Results of the POC elections.
7. Items C2–C7 and Agenda Item 14: Considered as scheduled.

Submitted by:

1. Mr.Karma Nidup, Chief Executive Officer, Bhutan Post
2. Mr.Jamyang Phuntsho, Head PSD, Bhutan Post
3. Mr.Thinley Wangchuk, Head CAIRD, Bhutan Post
4. Mrs.Rinchen Zangmo, Head CSD, Bhutan Post
5. Mrs.Wangmo Phuntsho Droenma, Head POD, Bhutan Post

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